

Forest School — From Disconnection to Regeneration

Healing, Hope, Innovation — 2026 Application Draft

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Grounding document of the Carpathian OER Commons: the programme proposal, published as a working draft and open to co-creation. It speaks from conviction, as an application does. The guide does not claim what it holds as results; the foundations paper, Sections 3 and 8, says where each conviction stands against the evidence. No child is named, dated, counted, or placed; all programme description is standing-format and undated. Points of Hutsul practice are marked [for the elders].

v0.28, 2026-09-27: prepared for publication — participants described only as coming from across the country; the Erdpuls method claimed as designed and documented; deadwood left as habitat; sources named for the epigraph, the proverb of ubuntu, and the discipline drawn from Goethe; Hutsul points marked for the elders.

"We are called to be architects of the future, not its victims." — attributed to Buckminster Fuller

Thesis

The thesis of Forest School is three-fold.

The first fold is near, and it is not a metaphor. A war is being fought in this country, and children carry it. Forest School leads war-affected children and youth into a literal Carpathian forest so that learning — discovered by them, never delivered to them — leads them out of the figurative one: the forest of war, loss, and disorientation. In tending the land they are tended by it; care circulates through children, mentors, elders, community, and forest until no one in the circle is only a giver or only a receiver. This is the school's first reason, and it would be reason enough.

The second fold is deep, and it is why the school would need to exist even in peace. The war did not create the wound the school answers; it tore the cover off it. Beneath the visible war lies a severance that is worldwide and wears a different face in every place: person cut from land, person from person, generation from generation, values from action. Open war is its most violent face — not its only one. The school's deeper reason is spiritual in the plainest sense of the word: it exists to practise reconnection — of child to ground, of person to person, of the present to its past and its future — and that need ends at no border and no ceasefire.

The third fold is forward, and it is the necessary one, because a school that existed only against a wound would end when the wound closed, and the first two folds alone would only mourn. Forest School exists for what it is growing: a generation that knows in its hands how to belong to a place, how to regenerate what is broken, how to receive from elders and hand on to those who come after — and a freely licensed model that other places can take up and fill with their own life. The wound explains the school's beginning; the gift explains its future. In many paths of the spirit the fold is three — what was, what is, what is coming — and it is the third that turns grief into work and work into hope.

The school orders its own life by the same conviction. Its convictions are lived in the open and pressed on no one: every pattern is named in the child's own words, and every family's faith walks with them unasked. One standing rule holds everyone — child, mentor, elder, guest — and no one stands above another. No place at the table is earned; every need is carried in common, and the only currency that circulates is care. The school practises this at the scale of a table and a working day. Nothing larger is claimed for it.

The three folds are one movement — named in clear thought, transformed through the feeling heart, grown by willing hands. The hand that heals a forest and the hand that heals a child are the same hand. What remains when a session ends — trees in the ground, a growing record of the place's own patterns, bonds between generations — is peace built as infrastructure, not conducted as process. An old Ukrainian proverb holds the whole: *Наyka в лiс не веде, а з лiсу виводить* — learning does not lead into the forest, it leads out of it.

Mission Statement

Forest School exists so that children and land can heal and grow — together, each through the other.

We do not heal anyone, and we do not teach in the old sense. We prepare ground, keep rhythm, and accompany. The healing is done by the forest, the circle, and the child, at the child's own pace; the learning is done by the learner. Our work is the gardener's work: tending the conditions in which growth does what only growth can do.

We bring children and youth from across the country into living relationship with a Carpathian forest, its community, and its elders, so that in tending what is wounded they are tended themselves. Through discovery rather than instruction, rhythm rather than pressure, and real work with real consequence, we tend the conditions in which each child grows the capacities no war can take: attention, belonging, competence, care, and hope.

We regenerate a forest, sowing and planting native trees into ground each cohort clears, composts, and feeds. We keep a record of the place's own patterns, written by children and elders together, and hand it on. We work as the mountains have always worked — together, across generations, with no place at the table earned and every need carried in common.

And we build all of this in the open: an ethos every family can read before choosing it, a method any community can take up freely, and a prototype co-created with this place so that other places, in other contexts and cultures, can grow their own form of the healing inside the same shape.

Executive Summary

Forest School is a residential programme for children and youth at a Hutsul highland site in the Ukrainian Carpathians, combining psychosocial rehabilitation, ecological education, values-based reflection, and youth-led social innovation. Participants come from across the country; every session runs with qualified psychological and medical presence, a defined mentoring ratio, and full meal provision. The programme applies the approach of Soil and Peace, a community regeneration practice: peace grown as infrastructure — capacities, relationships, and living systems that remain — rather than negotiated as process. It answers the documented values-action gap of environmental education by never separating the two: action is immediate, tangible, and recognised, and the learning is the acting.

The learning method is a pattern language of place, drawn from the Erdpuls open educational resource collection of that name. Children work as discoverers: attention moves outward through concentric rings — body, homestead, garden and forest edge, village, valley — through a four-stage pathway of Awareness, Acknowledgment, Attitude, and Action, and every discovery is recorded on safeguarding-adapted pattern cards that each cohort inherits from the last and extends. Beneath the method runs the three-beat movement of all regeneration — clearing, composting, building — which the forest teaches literally and the child is never made to perform. The body is the first instrument and simple measurement the second, admitted by a strict filter; the model is designed and documented in that collection, and Forest School carries it into a second landscape and language community.

In 2026 the programme carries seven components: a daily Morning Circle of gratitude and hope; the Forest of Peace regeneration strand, in which children work the soil, clear and compost, and sow, raise, and plant native trees; the "Hack for Hope" youth social innovation workshop, in which teams design responses to needs they have themselves observed; the Elders' Toloka, one or more intergenerational co-creation sessions in which elders of the community and region work beside the children and learning runs in every direction; the song and dance forms of the highland tradition [for the elders], freely entered and clinically held, through which grief leaves the body in community; the closing Evening of Light; and the Seeds of Hope recognition, which sends every child home seen and carrying a living seed of the work.

The pedagogy is grounded, at method level only, in Waldorf and Goethean practice — rhythm, head-heart-hands, observation before explanation — held within two firm boundaries: no doctrine is taught, and all cultural content is Hutsul and Ukrainian. Child protection is a non-optional condition throughout: no child is named, depicted, dated, counted, or placed in any published material, and all visiting adults work under the programme's safeguarding supervision. Youth empowerment and capacity building run through the whole as a trajectory: participant to peer mentor to co-facilitator across returning seasons, with the workshop roles and leadership steps stated as deliverables. Beneath every method lies the capacity they all serve — the sense of place, the practised ability to belong to real ground, held in the old threshold shape of separation, accompanied crossing, and return, without ordeal, with its ethos in the

open and doctrine pressed on no one. Outcomes are read at the level of the standing practice — the forest's recovery, the thickening pattern record, the returning elders, and the children's own return across seasons — never through any individual child.

1. What the Programme Is

Forest School is a residential programme for children and youth, delivered at a Hutsul highland site in the Ukrainian Carpathians. It combines psychosocial rehabilitation, ecological education, values-based reflection, and youth-led social innovation.

Participants come from across the country. The programme runs with qualified psychological and medical presence, a defined mentoring ratio, full meal provision, and a standing session format.

The programme applies the approach of Soil and Peace, a community regeneration practice: the conviction that the hand that heals soil and the hand that heals what lies between people is the same hand, and that peace is not a process to be negotiated but an infrastructure to be grown — capacities, relationships, and living systems that hold when events do not. A peace process ends when the signing ends. Peace infrastructure — a forest that children planted together, a circle of care they learned to stand inside, a pattern language they made their own — remains, and carries. Forest School is built as peace infrastructure.

The child's recovery orders the work in five movements: safety first — trust, groundedness, and personal boundary restored before anything else begins; the senses reopened, from war's numbness back to soil, scent, stillness, and joy; purpose and identity redefined — the child's self-perception moving from "victim of war" to creator, defender, and steward of life on their native land, so that Ukrainian youth grow not as a lost generation of war but as the Generation of Regeneration; faith in light and goodness restored through belonging to something larger and living; and the flourishing forest itself as living proof — telling each child a truth no words could carry, that they have the power to nurture, to heal, and to give life back to the world.

The forest is not the backdrop of the programme and not its object. It is a participant and a caregiver in its own right. The western habit of mind separates the human from a so-called wilderness; the peoples who have lived longest with their land — here, the Hutsuls of these highlands — did not make that cut [for the elders]. There is no wilderness in this valley. There is land in relationship: pasture, forest, garden, homestead, each tended and each tending back. The programme stands inside that older understanding. The children do not only learn in the forest and work on the forest — the forest works on them. Its quiet, its scale, its indifference to the war, its steady green insistence on continuing: these are the forest's side of the care.

2. What Innovation Means Here

An old Ukrainian proverb anchors the whole approach:

Наука в ліс не веде, а з лісу виводить. Learning does not lead into the forest — it leads out of it.

The forest of the proverb is the dark one: being lost, not knowing, fear. The programme takes the proverb at its word by an apparent contradiction — it leads children into the literal forest so that learning can lead them out of the figurative one. Among the trees, in work that has rhythm, meaning, and visible result, the forest of war — disorientation, loss, isolation — begins to loosen its hold. The child who learns the forest is no longer lost in it; the child who tends the forest is no longer only what the war made of them. The way into the trees is the way out of the dark.

Within that frame, innovation is not a technology and not a novelty. It is a change in the direction of agency.

The change answers a documented failure of conventional environmental education: the values-action gap. Large majorities of young Europeans say they care about the living world; far fewer carry that care into daily action, because knowing about a system is not the same as belonging to one. The gap closes when action is immediate, tangible, and recognised — a tree planted with one's own hands, a pattern discovered and named, a project presented to a real community. Forest School is built so that values and action are never separated in the first place: the child does not first learn and later act; the learning is the acting.

Much psychosocial support for war-affected children is, of necessity, delivered FOR them: care arrives, and they receive it. That work is necessary and it continues here. The innovation of Forest School 2026 is the deliberate second movement: the children are brought into work done WITH them — and then into work they lead themselves, done for the land and for others.

Innovation, in this context, is therefore defined as:

- **Circulation of care.** A child who arrives as a recipient of protection becomes a giver of care — to a forest, to a community idea, to another person's hope — and discovers, in giving it, that care was flowing toward them the whole time: from the mentors, from the peer group, from the land itself. The direction of care does not simply reverse; it becomes a circle. The community cares for the child, the child cares for the forest, the forest cares for the child, the child returns to care for the community. A person is a person through other persons, as the Nguni proverb of ubuntu has it — and, in this valley, through the land those persons belong to, which is our extension, not the proverb's. Neither caregiver nor cared-for is a fixed role; everyone and everything in the circle is both.
- **Integration, not addition.** Healing, ecological work, ethical reflection, and creative problem-solving are not four parallel activity blocks. They are one process, done by the same hand.

- **Rootedness in an indigenous form.** The working method is *toloka*, shared work known across these mountains and their neighbours: people doing together a piece of work none could do alone. The hackathon, the planting, the closing festival are all *toloka* in youth form. The innovation is not imported; it joins a practice the mountains already hold.
- **Discovery, not delivery.** The programme's learning method is the pattern language of place: children are not taught facts about the forest, they discover its patterns — and name them in their own words. A pattern language the children have not themselves discovered is not theirs; it is someone else's, imposed. The proverb holds here too: learning that is handed over leaves a child where it found them; learning a child makes their own is what leads out of the forest.
- **Empowerment as trajectory, not event.** Youth empowerment and capacity building are integral to the programme, and they are built as a path rather than a workshop: a child participates; a returning youth mentors younger peers; an older youth co-leads a team, a circle, a planting. Each return across seasons is a step from being held toward holding. The programme's aim is that its future facilitators are already inside it, growing.
- **Regeneration, not repair.** The programme does not aim to return children or land to a pre-war state. It aims to grow capacities — resilience, empathy, initiative, ecological literacy — that did not need to exist before and now do.

A question runs beneath these markers: are the children being formed as caregivers, or as stewards of the future? The programme holds that the question answers itself once the separation is refused. A steward manages something entrusted — the word still stands slightly outside and above what it tends. A caregiver stands inside a relationship, in the present tense, and is cared for in return. The children become caregivers now, within a living circle of care — and it is precisely this, not any management of the future, that the future will inherit. The future is not stewarded from a distance. It is grown, the way a forest is grown: by tending the present relationship well and trusting what it seeds.

3. The Method — A Pattern Language of Place

The programme's learning architecture is drawn from the Erdpuls open educational resource collection *Pattern Language of Place* and its Pattern Discovery Toolkit. Three structures from that collection carry the whole:

3.1 Patterns, Discovered Not Taught

Following Christopher Alexander, a pattern is a relationship that works — between a context, a tension, and a resolution observed to hold, repeatedly, over time. Every place has a pattern language; the task is not to invent it but to notice it. At Forest School the children work as pattern-discoverers: observing before explaining, describing what the forest shows them before being told what it means, and naming what they find in their own words. The method is phenomenological in the Goethean sense — *zarte*

Empirie, delicate empiricism — and follows a three-step discipline drawn from Goethe: *collect, order, form*. First the glance at the whole, which produces wonder; then the patient gathering of phenomena, with judgement held back; then the ordering, which is never forced but allowed to emerge from the things themselves; and only last the forming of a pattern — a lawfulness read from the phenomena, tested against further observation. The body is the first instrument; simple measurement (soil, water, species) is the second, and the dialogue between the two is where the learning happens.

Instruments are admitted by a filter, not by default: a tool enters the children's work only where it serves the encounter rather than replacing it — understandable and repairable, working with the day's rhythms rather than against them, appropriate to the place, connecting the children to the ground and to each other rather than to a screen, and generating no data that places any child or the site. The body always comes first; nothing with a battery precedes a hand in the soil.

Each discovered pattern is recorded on a pattern card — the tension it resolves, what was observed, how it connects to other patterns, what is not yet known. The cards accumulate across cohorts. Session by session, year by year, the children assemble the forest's own pattern language — a living document no single group could write alone, and each group inherits and extends. This is the *toloka* at the scale of knowledge.

The card format is adapted for safeguarding: cards carry no child's name and no coordinates. Discoveries are attributed to the cohort, and place is recorded at the level of the ring. The record belongs to the group and to the forest, not to any identifiable child.

3.2 The Concentric Rings

Attention moves outward from the centre, never the reverse — no maps or abstractions before the ground itself. Adapted to this site, the rings are:

- **Ring 0 — the body.** Embodied perception as the calibrating instrument. Bare attention: what does this place show you now?
- **Ring 1 — the homestead.** The buildings, materials, and micro-climates of the camp site itself.
- **Ring 2 — the garden and forest edge.** Where the closely tended and the self-willed land meet — not a boundary between human and wilderness, for there is none here, but a gradient of relationship; the regeneration strand works here.
- **Ring 3 — the village.** The settlement as a pattern-rich environment: craft, heritage, community forms.
- **Ring 4 — the valley.** Watershed, pasture, geology — the *polonyna* landscape as the widest frame of belonging.

Each ring is also a sensory register: at Ring 0 every channel is open — touch, smell, warmth, sound; at Ring 4, vision leads. The day's forms follow this grammar deliberately — the Morning Circle and shared work are gathering forms, seated in a round, hands in common material; solitary observation disperses; the Evening of Light gathers again around a single point of light.

3.3 The 4A-Pathway

Every learning sequence follows four stages, and the whole camp follows them as one arc:

- **Awareness** — *what is here?* The direct sensory encounter, protected from premature explanation. The forest work and the day's first encounters live here.
- **Acknowledgment** — *how does this connect to me?* Pattern naming; the recognition that what was observed matters — personally, locally, ecologically.
- **Attitude** — *what does this mean for how I want to live?* Values reflection; the questions of kindness, responsibility, and hope the circle carries.
- **Action** — *what will I do because of this?* The Hack for Hope projects, the trees planted, the seed carried home.

The pathway spirals rather than ends: a child who reached Awareness with a patch of soil one season may return the next and move into Acknowledgment with the same ground. The programme is built for that return — each cohort's pattern cards and planted trees are the standing invitation.

The proverb and the pathway are one movement. Awareness leads the child into the forest; Action leads them out of it — changed, carrying something, leaving something growing behind.

3.4 The Three Movements — Clearing, Composting, Building

Soil and Peace works in a three-beat movement, and the forest teaches it without being asked: *clearing* — *composting* — *building*. What is cleared; what is let to rot down and feed the next thing; what is raised.

In the forest, the movement is literal. The children leave standing and fallen deadwood as habitat and clear only what chokes the young growth; nothing cleared is discarded — it is composted, returned to the soil it came from, where it becomes the fertility the seedlings will stand in; and into that fed ground the new trees are planted. The waste of the old forest is the food of the new one. There is no away.

In the child, the same movement runs — and it is never named to the children, never assigned, never forced. The Morning Circle quietly makes room for clearing: what a child sets down there is their own to set down. Reflection and story let hard things break down slowly into something that can feed rather than poison. And the building — the planting, the projects, the seed carried home — rises out of that ground. The programme does not perform this parallel at the children; it trusts the forest to teach it, at each child's own pace, through the hands.

The camp arc follows the same beat: arrival and settling as clearing; the middle days of work, story, and rest as composting; the closing days — Hack for Hope, the Evening of Light, the Seeds of Hope — as building. One movement, four scales: the forest, the child, the session, and the year itself — autumn clears, winter composts, spring builds.

3.5 Technology — the Second Instrument

The programme refuses the old opposition of technology and nature. A thermometer in the soil and a hand in the soil are not rivals; they are two instruments asking the same question, and the gap between their answers is where the learning lives. The hand says: sheltered here, exposed there. The sensor says: three degrees warmer by the east wall. Neither reading replaces the other — the dialogue between them is a more complete way of knowing a place than either alone, and it teaches the children something larger than ecology: that measurement and reverence can hold the same object at the same time.

Rightly held, technology extends attention rather than replacing it. A simple measurement kept across the season — soil warmth, moisture, the returning species — watches the young trees through the weeks when no cohort is present, and the readings join the pattern record beside the children's own observations. Technology here does what the cohort-inheritance already does: it carries attention across time, so that each group receives not only the last group's trees and cards but its measurements, and the forest's recovery becomes legible across years.

At its best, human making is the forest's own intelligence continued through human hands — the leaf preceded the solar panel, the root web preceded the network. The children meet technology not as the opposite of the living world but as its apprentice. The filter in Section 3.1 is this same conviction stated as discipline: a tool is admitted where it serves life and the encounter, refused where it displaces them, and no tool generates data that places a child or the site.

3.6 Sense of Place — the Oldest Curriculum

Beneath every method in this section lies the capacity they all serve: the sense of place — the lived, embodied knowledge of belonging to a particular ground. Rings, patterns, pathway, measurement: each is a way of practising attachment to somewhere real. This is the oldest curriculum there is. Across cultures and ages, people have crossed out of the settled world into the forest, the mountain, the far pasture — always accompanied, by a guide, an elder, a healer — and returned changed, carrying something the community needed. The shape is constant: separation, threshold, return.

Forest School keeps the shape and holds it gently. The children leave home and cross into a held time among the trees; the mentors and elders are the accompaniment the old pattern always required; the Evening of Light marks the threshold; and every child returns carrying something — a pattern seen with their own eyes, a seed for their own ground, an intention spoken in the circle. The return is the point: the forest is entered so that home can be re-entered differently.

Two boundaries hold the old shape safe for these children. First, the shape transfers; the ordeal does not. The programme uses no isolation, no deprivation, no engineered crisis — the practices some traditions used to force the threshold. Children in psychosocial recovery need the opposite: safety, accompaniment, rhythm, and a forest allowed to work at each child's own pace. Second, the ethos in the open — doctrine to no one. The programme is not neutral and does not pretend to be. It holds convictions and lives them where they can be seen: that the land is alive with relationship; that care circulates until no one is only giver or only receiver; that attention ripens into attachment, attachment into care; that what is broken is not repaired but regenerated. These convictions belong to no one person and are imported from nowhere: they are co-created — by the household, the mentors, the elders, the children, and the place itself — and held in common, growing as the circle that holds them grows. And because the convictions are co-created rather than transplanted, the programme works as a prototype: what can travel to other contexts and cultures is the architecture — the rings, the pathway, the movements, the safeguards, the openness — never the content. Each new place that takes up the pattern fills it with its own memory, its own elders, its own names for things, and co-creates its own way of being inside the same shape. Families who choose the programme are choosing this way of being, and their choice is made real by openness: the ethos is stated plainly in what parents read before consenting, never discovered afterwards. What the programme will not do is turn the ethos into instruction — the convictions are enacted, never catechised; no metaphysical claim is taught to a child as truth; and the programme stands beside, never in place of, each family's own faith. Each child's belief, or none, walks with them unasked. The ceremonies, the reverence, the thresholds — these are human capacities older than any doctrine, and here they remain capacities: practised by all, imposed on none.

This curriculum carries a further gift, offered without ever being named to the children: the sense of place is a capacity, not only a bond to one ground. A child who has practised belonging — who has learned how attention becomes attachment and attachment becomes care — carries that practice to whatever ground their life reaches next. War can take a place. The capacity to belong, once grown, is harder to take.

4. The 2026 Components

4.1 Morning Circle of Gratitude and Hope

Each programme day begins with a twenty-minute reflective practice focused on emotional grounding and resilience.

Activities include:

- gratitude reflection
- short stories of courage and compassion
- guided reflection on kindness, responsibility, and hope

- moments of silence, with optional individual prayer
- sharing intentions for the day

The circle is rhythmic and predictable by design: the same form, the same time, every day. For children whose recent experience has been unpredictability, the reliability of the form is itself part of the therapy. The practice rests on universal humanitarian and spiritual values — empathy, solidarity, dignity, hope, mutual support — and is non-confessional throughout.

4.2 Forest of Peace — the Regeneration Strand (new)

The Forest of Peace is literal. Across the programme, children take part in hands-on forest regeneration on the programme site:

- beginning with the soil itself — hands in the ground before any tool, the soil observed, smelled, questioned, and fed, because a forest is grown from below and the ground is what holds
- leaving standing and fallen deadwood as habitat, clearing only what chokes the young growth, and composting what is cleared back into the soil — nothing cleared is thrown away
- collecting and sowing seed of native Carpathian species
- raising and planting seedlings
- tending young trees planted by earlier groups
- learning the forest as a living system — soil, water, fungi, succession — through direct work rather than lecture
- discovering and recording the forest's patterns on pattern cards (Section 3.1) — each cohort reading the cards of the last, testing them against the season, and adding its own
- keeping one living being through the session — each child chooses a tree or plant near the camp and returns to it daily for a few quiet minutes: not naming, not classifying, simply perceiving how it changes. Returning children resume their own being from the season before. Nothing is demanded of the child in these minutes but attention; what grows from long attention — attachment, and from attachment the wish to care — is the method's fruit, never its assignment.

The strand is designed by regenerative principles the forest itself demonstrates: observe and interact before intervening; prefer small and slow solutions on the seedling's timescale; produce no waste, since everything cleared feeds the ground; value diversity, planting the native mix rather than the single species; and work the edges, since the meeting of tended and self-willed land is where life is richest.

The work follows the mountain calendar, never the programme's convenience. Planting is confined to its true windows — after the spring thaw and before the autumn frost — and is never forced out of season to satisfy a schedule. Sessions outside the windows do the season's own regeneration work: sowing in beds, tending and watering, clearing and composting, collecting seed for cohorts to come, preparing

ground, and in winter reading the forest in snow, mending tools, and keeping the craft and story work of the elders' season. A cohort that gathers seed the cold holds until a later cohort plants it makes the inheritance literal across the turning year.

Each cohort inherits the work of the ones before it and leaves work for the ones after — trees in the ground and cards in the record. No child sees the forest finished; every child sees it further along. This is deliberate: it teaches that recovery — of a forest, of a country — is longer than any one person's effort and still depends on each person's effort.

The spiritual dimension is carried in the work itself, not in instruction: reverence practised as care for a living thing, patience practised on a seedling's timescale, hope practised as planting what one will not personally harvest. And the care runs both ways. While the children heal the forest, the forest heals the children — this is the conviction the strand is built on. The regeneration of the land and the regeneration of the child are one process observed from two sides.

Here the anchoring proverb is lived rather than quoted: the children go into the forest as learners and the learning leads them out — out of helplessness, out of the war's version of who they are — carrying knowledge the forest gave them and leaving the forest more alive than they found it.

4.3 "Hack for Hope" — Youth Social Innovation

In the closing days of each session, participants work in teams to develop creative responses to real needs: support for displaced families, protection of local ecosystems, stronger and kinder communities, youth-led recovery.

Ideas take form as handmade prototypes, posters, storytelling, simple digital concepts, and shared design sessions. The method is *toloka* at the scale of an idea: no team's project can be built by one member alone.

The hackathon is the Action stage of the 4A-Pathway made visible. Teams begin from patterns they have themselves discovered during the session — a tension noticed in the forest, the village, or their own communities — and design toward its resolution. The solutions are grown from what was observed, not imported from elsewhere; this is what makes them the children's own.

The workshop is also where capacity building is most explicit. Working in teams under light facilitation, participants practise capacities that outlast any single idea: cooperative work and shared decision-making, design from observation, giving form to a thought (prototype, poster, story), presenting to a community, and receiving response. Older youth take defined roles — team facilitation, time-keeping, presentation coaching — and returning youth step into co-leadership of the workshop itself, so that the programme's leadership pipeline runs through its own participants.

The forest is the workshop's design teacher. Before reaching for a solution, teams are invited to ask how the forest already solves the problem — how it stores, distributes, signals, repairs, endures — and to design from that answer. And every project, digital or handmade, is tested against a design ethic the

teams apply themselves: does it connect people or isolate them; can the people it serves understand and repair it; does it work with the place and its rhythms or against them; does it give more than it takes. The youth thereby practise not only making, but judging what is worth making — the capacity their generation will need most.

4.4 The Elders' Toloka — Intergenerational Co-Creation

In one or two sessions each year — more, as the relationship grows — elders of the community and the wider region are invited to join the programme, not as speakers but as co-workers. The form is the oldest one the mountains have: people of different ages doing a piece of work together that none could do alone.

The elders and the children plant, tend, and make side by side. Wisdom is not delivered from a podium; it surfaces in the work — the name of a plant, the reason a tool is held this way, how a slope was mown before machines, what this forest looked like sixty years ago and what stood where the young trees now go. The elder memory is treated as what it is: living data about the place, reaching further back than any instrument.

The learning runs in every direction:

- **Children learn from elders** — land knowledge, craft, songs, the names things carry in this valley, and the steadying fact of lives that have already passed through hard times and continued.
- **Elders learn from children** — the pattern cards, the simple measurements, fresh eyes on ground they know so well that habit has made parts of it invisible; and the plain sight of children planting trees on their mountainside, which is its own answer to a hard year.
- **Elders learn from each other, and children from children** — the shared work puts people beside neighbours and peers they might never otherwise work with, and the exchange inside each generation is as real as the exchange between them.

The pattern record gains a dimension of time. Elders can confirm, contest, or extend the children's discovered patterns — this corner was always wet; that wind means rain by evening; we called this by another name. Patterns, it turns out, are not only seasonal but generational, and the record becomes a conversation across decades.

Through these sessions the 4A-Pathway reaches into the past as well as the ground. The children move through the same four stages toward the living culture of the highlands that they move through toward the forest: Awareness — meeting a song, a tool, a dialect word, a way of mowing, directly and without explanation; Acknowledgment — the recognition that this is not folklore but inheritance, the way one's own people answered this land; Attitude — the question of what, of all this, I want to carry; Action — practising a craft, singing the song forward, and, where the elders consent, recording what they share so it joins the record. Technology serves here as the culture's respectful scribe, never its substitute: a

recording made with consent keeps a voice; only the practising keeps the practice. In this way the programme is not ignorant of the past and not ignorant of the tools of the present — it sets them to work for each other.

The elders' sessions are peace infrastructure in the most direct sense: bonds between generations, and between children from across the country and the people of this valley, that continue after the session ends. And they complete the circle of care — the community that cares for the children is cared for in return, seen, asked, and needed.

4.5 Song, Dance, and the Triumph of Life

From the highlands' own tradition — in which community meets grief and awe together, through night vigils of song, story, and game [for the elders] — the programme carries forms for releasing what war leaves in the body:

- **Singing out the pain.** Polyphonic singing and traditional song let trapped grief leave the body through breath and shared resonance — many voices holding what no single voice could.
- **Dancing out the trauma.** Rhythmic stomping and circle dances may loosen what fear held in the body, and give back the body's power and joy in movement.
- **Songs that bless.** Sessions close with bright, rising traditional songs turned toward life and the child's own future.

Two hands hold these forms together, always: the tradition-bearers of the valley, who carry the songs, dances, and games and judge their fitting use; and the programme's qualified psychological staff, who hold each child's safety within them. Every practice is entered freely, never required; grief is invited, never extracted; and a child who only watches from the circle's edge is honoured exactly where they stand. The tradition supplies the medicine; the clinical presence guards the dose. The valley is not alone in this knowledge: kin traditions from the Finno-Ugric north to the Baltic have met hard history the same way — in community, in the body, in song.

4.6 Evening of Light

Each session closes with a symbolic evening: teams present their ideas, reflections and gratitude are shared, and a candlelight moment holds hope for Ukraine. The evening is a festival in the old sense — a community marking a threshold together — and it answers, at the scale of the whole session, the form the Morning Circle opens each day.

4.7 Seeds of Hope — Recognition

Every participant is recognised at the close of the programme:

- a personalised certificate of participation
- a small symbolic token of the place
- a literal seed or seedling to carry home — the Forest of Peace extended into the child's own ground

Recognition names what each child carried into the common work. Recognition is universal and descriptive rather than ranked: every child is seen for something true, and no child is placed above another. It follows the work rather than purchasing it — nothing at Forest School is done for a reward or under a threat, and the recognition is never announced in advance as the price of participation.

5. Pedagogical Grounding

Several elements of the programme run structurally parallel to Waldorf / anthroposophically-informed pedagogy, and the 2026 draft makes that grounding explicit at method level:

- **Rhythm as therapy.** The fixed daily arc — circle, work, meal, work, rest — with the closing festival marking the session's threshold, mirrors the Waldorf principle that a breathing rhythm of concentration and release is itself stabilising for the child. For war-affected children this is not aesthetic preference; it is trauma-informed structure.
- **Head, heart, hands.** Every component engages thinking (design, ecology), feeling (gratitude, story, festival), and willing (planting, building, making). Nothing is taught that is not also done.
- **Reverence and gratitude as moods, not lessons.** Gratitude is practised in the circle and enacted on the land, never assigned as content to be learned. This matches the anthroposophical position that moral capacities in childhood are cultivated through atmosphere and imitation, not instruction.
- **Festival as pedagogy.** The Evening of Light functions as a seasonal festival: the community crosses a threshold together and the crossing is marked with light. The form is ancient and local before it is Waldorf; the mountains kept it.
- **The garden/forest as curriculum.** The regeneration strand stands in the tradition of Waldorf *Gartenbau* — cultivation work as a formative subject in its own right — extended here from garden to forest.
- **Developmental calibration.** The 4A-Pathway (Section 3.3) rests on Steiner's developmental phases, used strictly as a developmental psychology: in the younger years the will leads — knowledge must arrive through the hands and senses before it can enter the mind; in adolescence feeling awakens — knowledge lands deepest when it matters, not merely when it is true; in late adolescence judgement matures and asks to act. The programme's age band spans all three, and facilitators calibrate the pathway's depth accordingly: with the youngest, genuine Awareness is the whole achievement of a day; with the oldest, Attitude presses toward Action.
- **Observation before explanation.** The insistence that the sensory encounter precede interpretation is at once a Waldorf commitment and a Goethean scientific one — *zarte Empirie*, letting the phenomenon speak before the observer imposes categories. For war-affected children this discipline has a second value: it protects a space in which nothing is demanded of them but attention.

- **Attention ripens into care.** The Goethean pedagogical literature records what the method produces without ever aiming at it: long, unhurried attention to a living thing becomes attachment, and attachment becomes the readiness to act on its behalf. The programme relies on exactly this unforced sequence — observation to connection to care — as the route by which ecological responsibility grows in a child without ever being assigned.
- **Embodiment as therapeutic ground.** Phenomenological psychology holds that the felt sense of self is anchored in the body's rhythms, its contact with the ground, and its attunement to others working alongside — and that reliable rhythm steadies a person's lived sense of time. The programme's insistence on hands in the soil, fixed daily form, and shoulder-to-shoulder work is therefore not tradition alone; it is aligned with the contemporary clinical understanding of how stability and connection are rebuilt.
- **The seven developmental needs of youth.** The programme answers, by design, the seven developmental needs of young adolescents identified by the Center for Early Adolescence: physical activity (the forest work itself); competence and achievement (a tree planted, a prototype built, recognition that names what each child carried); self-definition (patterns named in one's own words, one being kept through the season, a project chosen by the team); creative expression (Hack for Hope, story, festival); positive social interaction (the toloka form, the teams, the elders); structure and clear limits (the fixed daily rhythm and the standing rules); and meaningful participation (real work with real consequence — a forest that grows, a record that lasts, ideas a community takes up). No component exists for one need alone; each meets several at once, which is what sustains engagement.
- **Learning without levers.** The programme uses no reward and no punishment to produce participation. A child moved by reward or threat is obeying, not learning; the learning that lasts is carried by meaning, and the research on motivation bears this out — external rewards reliably corrode the inner wish to do the very thing they reward, while lasting engagement runs on autonomy, competence, and belonging, which is precisely what every component here provides. Engagement at Forest School is carried by real consequence instead: a tree that lives or dies by the tending, a record that outlasts the session, an idea a community takes up. The Seeds of Hope recognition is guarded by the same principle — it follows the work and describes what was true, and is never announced in advance as participation's price: a mirror, never a carrot. In this the programme stands in a worldwide family of learning places — forest kindergartens, open-air and democratic schools, craft and land-based education — that trust the child's own wish to learn and build the conditions in which that wish can work.

The learning architecture in Section 3 is drawn from the Erdpuls *Pattern Language of Place* open educational resource collection (Pattern Discovery Toolkit, EN v1.3), which documents the method, its ring structure, and its developmental foundations in full and is published under the same CC BY-SA 4.0 license as this document. The method is designed and documented in that collection, with its origin at an environmental education ground on the German-Polish border in Brandenburg. Forest School carries the

model into a second landscape and a second language community — the same architecture, with all cultural content and all safeguarding discipline set by this place. The programme's inner side — its ethos, its tenets, and the co-created eco-spiritual philosophy it serves — is stated in the companion document "The Eco-Spiritual Philosophy of the Living Forest"; this document states the architecture, and the two stand together.

Two boundaries hold throughout:

1. **Method, not worldview.** The programme borrows pedagogical structure from this tradition. It teaches no doctrine, anthroposophical or otherwise, and all reflective practice remains non-confessional with silence and prayer optional.
2. **Cultural content is local.** Where the pedagogy is informed by Waldorf structure, the cultural substance — songs, stories, craft, agrarian knowledge, festival forms — is Hutsul and Ukrainian. The method serves the place; the place is not redecorated by the method.

6. Safeguarding

Child protection is a non-optional condition of the programme, not an annex to it. In all public and application materials: no child is named or depicted; no identifying detail is attached to any individual child; no session dates, arrival or departure timing, routes, or headcounts are published; programme description is given only in standing, undated format. A wartime addendum hardens these rules further given the programme's location. Qualified psychological and medical presence is maintained on site throughout every session. All adults present during sessions — including visiting elders and community members — take part under the programme's safeguarding supervision and its mentoring structure; participation in the intergenerational sessions is always in the open, in the group, and within the standing rules. Informed choice completes the protection: the programme's ethos and methods are stated plainly in the materials parents read before giving written consent, so that every family chooses with open eyes.

7. Signs the Work Is Working

The programme's outcomes are read the way the programme is run — patiently, at the level of the standing practice, never through any individual child:

- **The forest.** Area under active regeneration; seedlings planted and their survival across seasons; return of ground flora and species observed in the tended areas. The forest itself is the most honest evaluator the programme has.
- **The record.** Growth of the pattern-card record and the season-long measurement series across cohorts; patterns confirmed across seasons; patterns extended or contested by elders. A thickening record is a thickening relationship with the place.

- **The circle.** Elders returning; sessions requested again by the community; Hack for Hope ideas taken up beyond the camp.
- **The children.** Psychosocial progress is observed by the programme's qualified psychological staff using their standard professional instruments, held within the programme and never published; and the rate of return across seasons — children asking to come back to ground they have planted — is read as the programme's plainest sign.

8. Deliverables and Expected Results

Quantities marked [n] are set per funding cycle by the programme and its partners; they are stated here as the standing shape of the commitment. Nothing in this section names, dates, counts, or places any child.

Deliverables — what the programme produces

- **Programme delivery.** [n] residential sessions of [n] days delivered across the year — sessions can be held in any season, with each session's work set by its season — each with the full standing format: qualified psychological and medical presence, defined mentoring ratio, full meal provision.
- **Forest of Peace.** [n] hectares brought under active regeneration; [n] native seedlings raised and planted; an on-site composting cycle established and maintained; young trees from earlier cohorts tended through the season.
- **The pattern record.** The safeguarding-adapted pattern-card record established, maintained, and archived, together with a simple season-long measurement series (soil, moisture, returning species) that carries observation between cohorts; a first compiled edition of the site's pattern language produced at season's end, attributed to the cohorts collectively.
- **Youth capacity.** All participants complete the full 4A-Pathway within their session; older youth trained and exercised in defined peer-mentoring and co-facilitation roles; youth-led "Hack for Hope" projects documented and shared back to participants' communities of origin in a form the teams approve.
- **Intergenerational sessions.** Elders' Toloka sessions delivered; elder knowledge — names, practices, memory of the land — recorded into the pattern record with the elders' consent and attribution as they choose.
- **Open documentation.** The programme's method documented as place-anonymous open educational resources (CC BY-SA 4.0), transferable to other sites and initiatives.

Expected results — what changes because of it

- **In the children and youth:** improved psychosocial wellbeing, assessed by the programme's qualified staff with standard professional instruments and held within the programme; strengthened agency and self-efficacy — the felt move from cared-for to caregiver; ecological literacy grounded in a real place; and, for older and returning youth, demonstrated facilitation and leadership capacity.
 - **In the forest:** a measurable regeneration trajectory — seedling survival across seasons, returning ground flora, extending tended area — that each cohort advances.
 - **In the community:** recurring elder participation; bonds between the valley and children from across the country that outlast the sessions; youth-designed ideas taken up beyond the camp.
 - **In the field:** a documented, transferable model joining psychosocial rehabilitation to ecological regeneration and youth empowerment, available to other communities as open educational resources.
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9. Innovation Section — Condensed for the Application Form

In 2026, Forest School introduces an integrated innovation combining emotional healing, ecological regeneration, and youth-led social action, applying the approach of the community regeneration practice Soil and Peace: peace built as infrastructure — capacities, relationships, and living systems that remain — rather than as process. Its philosophy is held in a Ukrainian proverb: *Наука в ліс не веде, а з лісу виводить* — learning does not lead into the forest, it leads out of it. The programme leads children into the literal forest so that learning can lead them out of the figurative one — the forest of war, loss, and disorientation.

Daily reflection circles support emotional recovery through rhythm, gratitude, and community connection. The learning method is the pattern language of place: children discover and name the patterns of the forest, the homestead, and the valley themselves, moving through a four-stage pathway — Awareness, Acknowledgment, Attitude, Action — with the body as first instrument and simple measurement as the second, and each cohort inheriting and extending the pattern record of the last. A new hands-on regeneration strand — the Forest of Peace — has children sowing, raising, and planting native trees into ground they have cleared, composted, and fed, so that ecological recovery is learned by doing it. The "Hack for Hope" social innovation workshop empowers participants to develop, in teams, creative responses to needs they have themselves observed, with older and returning youth taking defined mentoring and co-facilitation roles — youth empowerment built as a trajectory from participant to co-leader. Intergenerational co-creation sessions bring elders of the community and region into the shared work — knowledge, craft, and memory flowing in every direction, and bonds forming between generations that outlast the programme. The closing Evening of Light and Seeds of Hope recognition send every child home seen, and carrying a living seed of the work.

The innovation is the direction of the whole: care circulates. Children who arrive as recipients of care become caregivers — to a forest, to a community, to one another — and are cared for in return by the land itself, which the programme treats not as wilderness apart from the human but as a participant in the healing. Psychosocial rehabilitation is thereby joined to agency, and healing to regeneration — of the child and of the forest, as one process.

Release record

- **Gate 1:** 2026-09-27, the household, recorded by Michel Garand — for publication online as a working draft, open to co-creation and to change.
 - **Wartime review:** 2026-09-27, Michel Garand — names Soil and Peace and no place; participants described only as coming from across the country; programme described in standing format only; accepted.
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